# Policy Changes Inventory

*LIHEAP and SNAP/CalFresh | San Diego, California | Study period: January 2018 – July 2025*

**Purpose:** Document the federal, California, and San Diego–level policy changes during the study period that affected LIHEAP and SNAP/CalFresh eligibility criteria, benefit amounts, and program funding.

**Scope note:** No policy changes enacted by the City of San Diego itself were identified for January 2018 – July 2025. The City does not administer these programs: CalFresh is run by the County of San Diego under state and federal rules, and LIHEAP is delivered by nonprofit Local Service Providers under contract with the California Department of Community Services and Development (CSD). Local implementation differences are documented in Section 6.

## Key Dates at a Glance

| Date | Change | Program |
|---|---|---|
| Dec 20, 2018 | 2018 Farm Bill signed | SNAP |
| Jun 1, 2019 | SSI “cash-out” reversed; SSI recipients become eligible for CalFresh | CalFresh |
| Mar 2020 | Emergency Allotments begin (FFCRA); CARES Act adds $600/week UI and $900M for LIHEAP | CalFresh, UI, LIHEAP |
| Mar 2020 – Sep 30, 2021 | CPUC moratorium on utility disconnections | Utilities / LIHEAP |
| Jan – Sep 2021 | Temporary 15% increase to maximum SNAP benefits | CalFresh |
| Mar 11, 2021 | American Rescue Plan Act: $4.5B for LIHEAP, UI extended to Sep 2021 | LIHEAP, UI |
| Sep 4–6, 2021 | Federal pandemic unemployment programs end | UI |
| Oct 1, 2021 | Thrifty Food Plan re-evaluation raises SNAP benefits 21% | CalFresh |
| Nov 15, 2021 | Infrastructure Investment and | LIHEAP |

| Date | Change | Program |
|---|---|---|
| | Jobs Act: $100M/year for LIHEAP | |
| Mar 26, 2023 | Final CalFresh Emergency Allotment issued; benefits drop in April 2023 | CalFresh |
| May 11, 2023 | Federal COVID-19 Public Health Emergency ends | CalFresh |
| Jun 3, 2023 | Fiscal Responsibility Act changes ABAWD rules | SNAP |
| Jul 1, 2023 | ABAWD time limit resumes; temporary student exemptions end | CalFresh |
| 2023 | San Diego County migrates to CalSAWS / BenefitsCal | CalFresh |
| FY2024 | Federal LIHEAP funding falls from $6.1B to $4.125B | LIHEAP |
| Dec 2024 | SDG&E CBO Arrears Case Management Pilot begins | Utilities / LIHEAP |
| Feb – Jun 2025 | Chip-enabled EBT cards rolled out statewide | CalFresh |
| Apr 1, 2025 | Federal LIHEAP staff dismissed; final FY2025 funds released May 1 | LIHEAP |
| Jul 4, 2025 | One Big Beautiful Bill Act signed | SNAP, LIHEAP link |

# 1. Federal Policy Changes Affecting California LIHEAP Eligibility and Benefit Amounts

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### What are the rules for LIHEAP enrollment?

LIHEAP's federal eligibility rules did not change between January 2018 and July 2025. To enroll, a household must meet the income limit and submit documentation.

- **Income limit:** at or below the greater of 150% of the federal poverty guideline or 60% of state median income.

- **Documentation:** typically name, address, Social Security number, housing situation (rent or own), household size, heating source and provider, and total monthly income.

*Source: BenefitsCheckUp – How do I apply for LIHEAP?*

### Federal policies and legislation that influenced LIHEAP in California

| Policy / date | What it did | Source |
|---|---|---|
| **CARES Act**<br>March 2020 | Provided $900 million in supplemental LIHEAP funding for FY2020. California received approximately $49.5 million. | CA Senate Office of Research |
| **American Rescue Plan Act**<br>March 2021 | Provided $4.5 billion in supplemental LIHEAP funding, available through FY2022. California received $204.4 million. | CA Senate Office of Research |
| **Infrastructure Investment and Jobs Act**<br>November 2021 | Appropriated $100 million for LIHEAP in each of FY2022–FY2026, in addition to regular annual funding. | American Public Power Association |
| **HHS staff dismissals**<br>April 2025 | The entire federal LIHEAP staff (about two dozen people) was dismissed on April 1, 2025, in mass layoffs at HHS. The remaining $378 million in FY2025 funding was held up until its release on May 1, 2025, after bipartisan pressure. | NBC News; NEFI |

*Note: The CARES Act and American Rescue Plan allocations were intended to help California households cover heating and cooling costs, clear utility arrearages, and support home weatherization repairs.*

## 2. SNAP/CalFresh Program Rules and Benefit Levels

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### What are the rules for SNAP enrollment?

To qualify, a household must meet income and asset limits and must not fall under certain categorical exclusions.

- **Income limits:** gross monthly income generally at or below 130% of the poverty line (about $2,888/month for a family of three in FY2026); net income after deductions at or below the poverty line.
- **Asset limits:** $3,000 or less for most households; $4,500 or less for households with a member aged 60+ or with a disability.
- **Counted income and assets:** income from all sources (earned and unearned, including Social

Security, unemployment, and child support) is counted. Assets such as bank balances count; a home, personal property, retirement savings, and most vehicles do not.
- **Categorically ineligible:** some people do not qualify regardless of income or assets, including people on strike, undocumented immigrants, many lawfully present immigrants, some college students enrolled half-time or more, and, in some states, people with certain drug felony convictions.
- **Work requirement / time limit (ABAWDs):** able-bodied adults without dependents are limited to three months of benefits in three years unless they work or train at least 20 hours a week. The covered age range was 18–49 for most of the study period, rose to 18–54 by October 2024, and expanded to 18–64 under the July 2025 reconciliation law.

*Source: Center on Budget and Policy Priorities – A Quick Guide to SNAP Eligibility and Benefits*

## Federal policies and legislation that influenced SNAP in California

| Policy / date | What it did | Source |
|---|---|---|
| **2018 Farm Bill**<br>December 2018 | Kept the existing ABAWD time limit for adults 18–49 (three months of benefits in three years unless working 20+ hours a week or exempt) and reduced the share of their caseload states may exempt from 15% to 12%. Also required USDA to re-evaluate the Thrifty Food Plan by 2022. | FRAC – SNAP Time Limits Q&A |
| **Thrifty Food Plan re-evaluation**<br>October 2021 | Permanently raised maximum SNAP benefits by about 21%, the first update to the Thrifty Food Plan's contents since 2006. | NIH – 2021 Thrifty Food Plan Re-evaluation |
| **Fiscal Responsibility Act of 2023**<br>June 2023 | Raised the ABAWD age ceiling in phases (50 in Sept. 2023, 52 in Oct. 2023, 54 in Oct. 2024; sunsets Oct. 2030) and added exemptions for people experiencing homelessness, veterans, and former foster youth. Cut state discretionary exemptions from 12% to 8% of caseload and capped carryover at one year. Added employment to SNAP's stated purpose and required USDA to post state waiver requests and approvals publicly. | USDA – SNAP Provisions in the FRA |
| **One Big Beautiful Bill Act** | Expanded the ABAWD work requirement to ages 18–64 | EmployReward Solutions – |

| Policy / date | What it did | Source |
|---|---|---|
| July 4, 2025 | (from 18–54), narrowed the caregiver exemption to parents of children under 14, and removed the exemptions for veterans, people experiencing homelessness, and former foster youth. Raised states' share of administrative costs to 75% (from 50%), required future Thrifty Food Plan re-evaluations to be cost-neutral, and reduced projected SNAP spending by about $186 billion over ten years. | SNAP Rules Under OBBBA |

## 3. COVID-19 Emergency Provisions (Expanded SNAP, Enhanced Unemployment)

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| Policy / date | What it did | Source |
|---|---|---|
| **Families First Coronavirus Response Act**<br>March 2020 | Allowed states to issue SNAP Emergency Allotments that raised each household's benefit to the maximum for its size, approved by the Food and Nutrition Service month by month. From April 2021, every household received at least $95 a month. California issued allotments from March 2020 through February 2023. | CalFresh Guide – COVID-19 Benefit Increases |
| **CARES Act**<br>March 2020 | Added a $600 weekly federal supplement (FPUC) to state unemployment benefits through July 25, 2020, raising an average $378 weekly benefit to $978. Also created Pandemic Unemployment Assistance for workers not normally eligible, such as the self-employed. | CNBC – Unemployment Benefits |
| **Temporary 15% SNAP increase**<br>January – September 2021 | The December 2020 relief law raised maximum SNAP benefits by 15% for January–June 2021; the American Rescue Plan Act | USDA – 15% SNAP Increase |

| Policy / date | What it did | Source |
|---|---|---|
| | extended it through September 2021 (about $27 more per person per month). | |
| **End of enhanced unemployment**<br>September 2021 | The American Rescue Plan Act extended the $300 weekly federal supplement and pandemic unemployment programs through September 6, 2021. Seventeen states announced plans to end them early; California kept them until the federal expiration. | Ballotpedia – States Ending Federal UI |
| **Thrifty Food Plan re-evaluation**<br>October 2021 | Replaced the temporary 15% increase when it expired September 30, 2021. Raised the maximum benefit for a family of four to $835 and average benefits by about $36 per person per month. | Penn Wharton Budget Model – 2021 SNAP Expansion |
| **Consolidated Appropriations Act, 2023**<br>Enacted Dec. 2022; effective March 2023 | Ended SNAP Emergency Allotments after the February 2023 issuance, separating them from the Public Health Emergency. The savings helped fund a permanent Summer EBT program providing grocery benefits to low-income families with school-age children in the summer. California issued its final allotment on March 26, 2023. | CBPP – Temporary Pandemic SNAP Benefits |
| **End of the Public Health Emergency**<br>May 11, 2023 | Ended USDA's authority to grant states pandemic workload flexibilities for processing SNAP applications and caseloads. The ABAWD time limit resumed July 1, 2023, and the temporary college student exemptions ended for applications filed on or after June 10, 2023 and recertifications from July 1, 2023. | CBPP – End of the PHE and SNAP |
| **Fiscal Responsibility Act of** | Raised the upper age limit for | Congress.gov – H.R. 3746 |

| Policy / date | What it did | Source |
|---|---|---|
| **2023**<br>June 3, 2023 | the ABAWD work requirement from 49 to 54 (phased in through October 2024) and added exemptions for veterans, people experiencing homelessness, and former foster youth. Cut state discretionary exemptions from 12% to 8% and required USDA to publish all ABAWD waiver requests and approvals. | |
| **One Big Beautiful Bill Act**<br>July 4, 2025 | Reduced projected SNAP funding by about $186 billion over ten years. Extended an annual $4 million grant program for food rescue and donation within The Emergency Food Assistance Program (TEFAP). | Congressional Research Service – R48552 |

## 4. Public Health Emergency (PHE) End Impacts

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| Policy / date | What it did | Source |
|---|---|---|
| **End of the Federal COVID-19 PHE Declaration**<br>May 11, 2023 | • Insurers were no longer required to waive costs or provide free COVID-19 tests.<br>• Paxlovid stayed free while supplies lasted; afterward, pricing depended on the manufacturer and insurance.<br>• Hospital admissions moved from daily to weekly reporting, and vaccine administration counts from weekly to monthly.<br>• COVID-19 death data now comes from the National Vital Statistics System, and test positivity is reported regionally through NREVSS. | CDC – End of the Federal COVID-19 PHE |

| Policy / date | What it did | Source |
|---|---|---|
| | • Case and death counts were removed from the COVID Data Tracker, and county-level test positivity ended because laboratories no longer had to report results. | |

*Note: The PHE's end mainly changed health programs and data reporting. Its effects on SNAP/CalFresh (ABAWD time limit and student exemptions) are listed in Section 3.*

## 5. California State-Level Changes Affecting CalFresh and LIHEAP

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| Policy / date | What it did | Source |
|---|---|---|
| **SSI "Cash-Out" reversal**<br>June 1, 2019 | AB 1811 ended California's policy barring SSI recipients from CalFresh, making roughly 500,000 older adults and people with disabilities newly eligible. | UCSF – SSI Cash-Out Reversal |
| **CPUC utility disconnection moratorium**<br>March 2020 – September 30, 2021 | Barred gas and electric shutoffs for nonpayment during the pandemic, including for SDG&E customers. When it ended, utilities had to enroll residential customers with overdue balances in long-term payment plans. | CPUC – June 2021 Press Release |
| **California Arrearage Payment Program (CAPP)**<br>2021 and November 2022 | Applied automatic bill credits for energy debt accrued during the pandemic: $1 billion in 2021 (debt from March 2020 – June 2021) and $647 million in 2022 (debt through December 2021). | CSD – California Arrearage Payment Program |
| **California Food Assistance Program (CFAP) expansion**<br>2024–25 budget | Addressed the planned expansion of state-funded food benefits to low-income undocumented Californians aged 55 and older. *Verify implementation timing: the expansion was delayed and may fall outside the study period.* | Legislative Analyst's Office – CalFresh and CFAP |

| Policy / date | What it did | Source |
|---|---|---|
| **Chip-enabled EBT cards**<br>February – June 2025 | Funded about $75 million to replace EBT cards with chip and tap-to-pay cards to combat benefit theft through card cloning. Mass replacement began in late February 2025, with all cards deployed by June 30, 2025. | Legislative Analyst's Office – 2025–26 Budget: Food Assistance |
| **One Big Beautiful Bill Act (LIHEAP–SUA link)**<br>July 2025 | Ended automatic eligibility for the higher Heating and Cooling Standard Utility Allowance based on receiving a LIHEAP payment, except for households with an older adult or a person with a disability. All other households must document actual heating and cooling costs to claim the higher allowance. | FRAC – SNAP Standard Utility Allowance |

## 6. San Diego County Implementation Variations

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| Policy / date | What it did | Source |
|---|---|---|
| **Split LIHEAP administration**<br>Ongoing | LIHEAP in San Diego County is delivered by two nonprofit providers divided by zip code: MAAC (South Bay, East County, and southeastern San Diego, including city zips 92113, 92114, 92139, 92154, and 92173) and Campesinos Unidos, Inc. (the remaining zip codes). Wait times and processing can differ by provider. *The zip-code split is documented from current provider pages; confirm it held for 2018–2025 using CSD contract records.* | MAAC – Energy Assistance |
| **Categorical eligibility through CalFresh**<br>Ongoing (federal rule) | Households receiving CalFresh or CalWORKs are categorically eligible for LIHEAP and can verify income with a current award letter, lowering the documentation burden. This | MAAC – Energy Assistance |

| Policy / date | What it did | Source |
|---|---|---|
| | applied throughout the study period. | |
| **CalWIN to CalSAWS migration**<br>2023 | San Diego County moved its eligibility system from CalWIN to CalSAWS and its online portal to BenefitsCal; all 58 counties had completed the move by October 31, 2023. System migrations can cause temporary processing backlogs. *Exact San Diego go-live date to be confirmed.* | California Association of Food Banks – SAWS Migration |
| **SDG&E CBO Arrears Case Management Pilot**<br>December 2024 – April 2026 | CPUC-ordered pilot (framework April 2022; approved February 15, 2024) in which MAAC provides case management to SDG&E customers at least 90 days past due. Limited to five City of San Diego zip codes: 92102, 92104, 92105, 92115, and 92116. | SDG&E – CBO Pilot |

## 7. Funding Changes (Appropriations Increases and Decreases)

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| Policy / date | What it did | Source |
|---|---|---|
| **Federal LIHEAP appropriations**<br>FY2018 – FY2025 | National LIHEAP funding by fiscal year:<br>● **FY2018:** $3.64 billion<br>● **FY2019:** $3.69 billion<br>● **FY2020:** $4.64 billion ($3.74B regular + $900M CARES Act)<br>● **FY2021:** about $8.25 billion ($3.75B regular + $4.5B American Rescue Plan)<br>● **FY2022:** $3.9 billion in new funding ($3.8B regular + $100M IIJA)<br>● **FY2023:** $6.1 billion ($4.0B base + $2.0B supplemental + $100M IIJA) | ACF – LIHEAP Funding Releases |

| Policy / date | What it did | Source |
|---|---|---|
| | • **FY2024:** $4.125 billion ($4.025B regular + $100M IIJA)<br>• **FY2025:** $4.125 billion ($4.025B regular + $100M IIJA) | |
| **CalFresh Emergency Allotments**<br>March 2020 – March 2023 | California issued about $14 billion in federally funded Emergency Allotments to nearly 3 million households. | California Association of Food Banks – Emergency Allotments |
| **2021 Thrifty Food Plan update**<br>Announced August 2021; effective October 1, 2021 | Increased the average SNAP benefit by $36.24 per person per month (about $1.19 per day) for FY2022. | USDA – Thrifty Food Plan Update |
| **End of Emergency Allotments**<br>March 2023 | Every household in the 35 states still receiving allotments lost at least $95 a month, about $90 per person on average. In California, the loss averaged $163 per household (about $425 million a month statewide). | CBPP – Temporary Pandemic SNAP Benefits |
| **One Big Beautiful Bill Act**<br>July 2025 | Reduced projected SNAP spending by about $186 billion over ten years and raised states' share of administrative costs to 75%. | Congressional Research Service – R48552 |